

**In what ways do digital capitalism and influencer culture amplify
neoliberal patriarchal dynamics by monetizing feminist expression
and activism?**

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Abstract

This paper adopts a critical lens in the attempt of addressing the ambivalence that the impact of Digital Capitalism and Influencer Culture poses on the contemporary gender politics, it investigates and examines the questions concerning how the monetization of feminist expression and activism in the digital age either amplifies or alters the patriarchal dynamics under the backdrop of neoliberalism (which instigates the need of self-branding and self-entrepreneurialism). This study inquires the validity and credibility of two fundamental vantage points regarding the questions posed on the aforementioned concern, whereby one position advocates the potential and capability of the platform economy in spearheading the objectives of feminist social justice through offering a vehicle for social change that can be brought about about discussions and deliberations about gender identity and sexuality and the other position argues that digital labour and social media platforms merely commodifies feminist expression and activism along with diluting its political force. The analysis of this inquiry is undertaken through identifying and engaging with two opposing hypothesis, namely, the ‘reinforcement hypothesis’ that posits that algorithm and economic imperatives of digital platforms co-opt feminism and reduces its political project to mere individualized, consumption based self-care which in turn furthers existing patriarchal and neoliberal structures on the one hand and the ‘reformation hypothesis’ that advocates how these platforms enable voices from the margins and forge new counterpublics and subcultures along with instrumenting the objectives of a global reach which furthers the goal of radical re-evaluation and revolutionization of the understanding of gender. This studies deploys qualitative research methods of (i) ‘content analysis’ which was applied with the intent of systematically thematizing and framing the commercial nature of high-engagement feminist content across key platforms, along with (ii) ‘discourse analysis’ to

critically deconstruct the linguistic and visual rhetoric utilized by prominent feminist influencers. This paper then demarcates the discourse to comprehend the specific arguments and concerns that are central to each of the hypothesis which are used as a foreground to gauge how digital capitalism and influencer culture either promote a commodified and depoliticized form of feminism (i.e., the reinforcement hypothesis) or instrument collective action and systemic critique (i.e., reformation hypothesis). The findings are presented in a nuanced conceptual and theoretical framework for furthering the understating of the future trajectory of digital feminism within the prevailing political-economic landscape.

Over the last decade or so, digital media platforms have transformed how culture, politics and identity are formed and communicated. Online platforms like Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, and Tumblr have created social media economies that convert visibility, intimacy and self-expression into measurable commodities. Due to this, influencer culture has established itself as a powerful force that shapes modern-day culture and political expression. Ordinary users turned influencers now function as micro-celebrities, cultural intermediaries, and political symbols, producing content that is simultaneously personal, commercial, and ideological. Scholarship on platform capitalism contends that these systems depend on data extraction, algorithmic curation, and the monetisation of everyday life, where social interactions become economic activity, and personal narratives- commodities. In this landscape, feminist expression has become one of the most prominent and profitable forms of online identity-making.

At first, digital platforms appeared to radically empower the feminist movement through hashtag activism, consciousness-raising threads, survivor testimonies, or community archives. These present a participatory model of engagement fueled by agency. Social media allowed the bypass of traditional barriers and coordinated collective action against power in an

unprecedentedly efficient way. Movements like #MeToo, #YesAllWomen, #WhyLoiter, #DalitWomenFight, and Indonesia's digital gender-justice campaigns could aid the feminist movement by amplifying women's voices beyond the lacking institutional recognition. Early social media supported accessibility, decentralised leadership, and cross-border solidarity and made it possible for anyone with access to the internet to voice their opinions and struggles while demanding accountability.

However, the very systems that supported the feminist struggle became increasingly structured and thereby limited due to the rise of digital capitalism as platforms evolved into profit-driven structures. Algorithmic visibility systems began privileging content that was emotionally charged, visually appealing, and commercially valuable. This was a criterion that pushed feminist expression toward digestible, marketable narratives. Simultaneously, the commodification of influencer activism transformed political expression into aestheticised performances of identity. Feminist activism, once grounded in collective struggle, became corrupt with self-branding, sponsorships, curated vulnerability, and the pursuit of engagement metrics.

This shift led to the rebranding of feminist identities like empowerment, which is no longer framed as a political demand but rather a lifestyle choice. Scholars describe this phenomenon as the "platformisation" of feminism, a process through which feminist language, symbols, and affect are absorbed into commercial cultures of influence. Under digital capitalism, visibility becomes currency; under neoliberalism, individuality becomes the primary mode of feminist expression. Together, they produce a marketplace of empowerment in which feminism is less of a social movement compared to a personal brand.

We can attribute digital capitalism to causing this transformation. Platforms monetise feminist expression by embedding it within data-driven advertising systems. Influencers, whether tradwives monetising domestic aesthetics, global lifestyle creators branding empowerment, or activists navigating precarious digital infrastructures, operate in economies structured by algorithmic reach, sponsorship deals, and the extraction of intimate, affective labour. Even ideologies that appear anti-consumerist or anti-modern, such as the “tradwife” resurgence, are made hyper-visible through platform logics that convert aestheticised nostalgia into profitable content. These contradictions show how platform economies can commodify both feminist and anti-feminist rhetoric with ease as long as they generate engagement.

This agenda is amply fied by neoliberalism that reframes empowerment as and individual project of self- management. This is apparent in Italian influencer, Chiara Ferragni. The feminist rhetoric she delivers online is tied to personal success narratives, entrepreneurial confidence, and curated authenticity. Political concepts like freedom, autonomy, and choice are repackaged as affective commodities aligned with branding and lifestyle curation. With the motive of market visibility at the forefront, the body itself becomes a tool for self-advertisement while emotions, vulnerabilities, and intimate experiences are transformed into spectacles of empowerment. Through this paradigm, feminism loses its collective, redistributive demands and intent. Instead, it becomes an ethos of self-improvement, positivity, and aspirational femininity.

In the conext of the Global South, this neoliberal-patriarchal configuration is exhibit in different forms. For instance feminist activism in Indonesia is plagued by digital harassment, algorithmic invisibility, legal threats, and state–platform alliances that suppress dissent. The experiences of these feminists reveal another aspect of the paradox; while digital platforms claim to democratise expression, they reinforce structural inequalities through uneven access, political

surveillance, and patriarchal governance. Activists must navigate a volatile structure that includes marketised influencer culture and state- regulated governance that inherently punishes feminist critique. This leads to spaces that promised liberation being used as avenues that expose women and queer communities to intensified precarity.

Uniting the ideas discussed so far reveal the paradox of this paper; digital platforms simultaneously expand and constrain feminist expression. The digital economy amplifies visibility while commodifying it, it gives space for critique within bond-friendly narratives it appears to democratise activism while embedding it in patriarchal, neoliberal infrastructures that monetises identity and affect. Feminism thrives in this neoliberal environment as long as it becomes more marketable, aestheticised, and less structurally confrontational.

Thus, this paradox outlines my central research question: in what ways do digital capitalism and influencer culture amplify neoliberal patriarchal dynamics by monetizing feminist expression and activism? This question is relevant as it addresses the intersection of economics, culture, gender politics, and digital technology instead of analysing them as isolated subjects. Understanding these dynamics goes beyond academic inquiry and is essential for the future of feminism.

This paper attempts to advocate that there are two ways through which digital infrastructure tends to profit from the monetization of the data and discourse that it collects from feminist expression and activism as it packages those data points and repurposes them for the curation of adverts, and the fellow way is more nuanced but the whims of attention economy tends to create an environ where it establishes the moulds that it expects people to fall under through the creation of different lingos, personas and behavioral patterns which stem from an

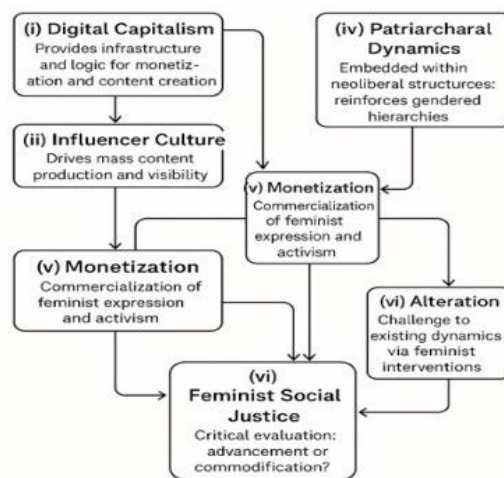
underlying appropriation of the male-gaze or the market gaze because drawing attention often requires creators to follow the trails of those who have already attained success or how the arbitrary nature of the ‘monetization’ itself across different social media platforms like youtube and metaverse etc. because the ways the content creators monetize their contribution to such platforms, as they don’t explicitly pay enough for the content one makes but creators are forced to monetize their face-value or the value of the labour that they put in their creation through different ways, either through brand endorsements, collaborations or subscriptions. Hence, this furthers the paradox of benevolence and malevolence because all the credibility and nobility that they acquire through the creation of authentic content then gets repurposed either by themselves or someone else to be able to market certain goods and services.

Considering that the neo-liberal ethos rests upon the spirit of entrepreneurship and self-branding wherein individuals themselves are encouraged to package themselves in ways that their value is reflected in the presentation of their selves in everyday lives, this is further amplified in the atmosphere of digital capitalism and influencer culture because one’s worth is determined by the metrics of one’s reach and the engagement of the content that they make. As “people do what society rewards them to do”, the questions of ‘agency’ and ‘autonomy’ which have been the core concerns of feminist social justice stand at a perplexing crossroads of a supposed paradox because questions concerning how does patriarchy reinforces itself through the rewards structures it establishes cannot be answered without taking into consideration the revolutionary role that the digital infrastructure has played in subverting the idea of what an ideal woman is and how feminist expression and activism have also twisted and turned the reward structure in ways that encourage resilience and perseverance. This brings us to the question of ‘monetization’ and how the ‘ability’ to ‘monetize’ should not merely be seen through the lens of

subservience whereby one holds that monetization is a product of succumbing to whims of those who are willing to pay and hence builds a burden towards adhering to the gaze or suppositions of behavior that would reap monetary reward, whereas, the other side of the ‘monetization’ is establishing a sense of credibility and validity towards one’s self, the likes that the digital and social structures reward through the pursuit of ‘awe, inspiration and prestige’ which isn’t necessarily a by-product of succumbing but can indeed be stemming from the strength one displayed through subversion.

Conceptual Framework

This section aims to explicate the contentions behind the concepts being deployed in this study and aims to clarify how those concepts are being understood and engaged with for the sake of making the understanding of the author explicit. Considering that there are a lot of interpretations of the terms being deployed and the exercise of ascertaining the author’s subjective understanding derived by the scholastic discourse that the author has been exposed to in the process of contemplation and investigation of the subject in hand.



Flowchart of the Conceptual Framework deployed in this study

Digital Capitalism: As per this study, digital capitalism refers to the contemporary phase of capitalism where digital technologies and platforms constitute the primary infrastructure for economic activity. It operates by embedding data-driven systems and algorithmic governance into production, distribution and consumption processes which facilitates the objective of dismantling traditional spatial and temporal barriers in the circulation of capital (Fuchs, 2024). Through platforms and big data analytics, digital capitalism creates multi-sided markets that enable instantaneous transactions and global connectivity, facilitating the frictionless exchange of goods, services, and information such an infrastructural transformation not only accelerates capital flows but also reconfigures value chains by integrating users, producers, and intermediaries into networked ecosystems (Langley & Leyshon, 2023). The digital infrastructure plays a two-pronged role of technological, as well as, a socio-economic architecture that optimizes accumulation through leveraging participatory cultures and network effects which holds the potential for raising critical questions concerning the interplay of power, inequality and control in the arena of digital economy (Nayak & Walton, 2024; Pace, 2018).

Influencer Culture: Influencer culture has originated with the alterations in the way that media is consumed in a personalized screen as opposed to how it was earlier consumed in shared screens, it has become a pivotal development in the arena of digital advertising as it has drastically altered the ways in which brands communicate and engage with consumers (Abidin, 2021). This culture has developed in the backdrop of the rise of attention economy which holds that human attention is a scarce and monetizable resource, in such an environment social media influencers serve the role of becoming a critical node for capturing and directing the focus of the desired audience (Beriwal et al., 2024). Brands approach influencers at the behest of their

credibility, reach and perceived authenticity in order to garner legitimacy for the goods and services they offer through transforming promotional messages and repackaging them as trusted recommendations (Talesara, 2025). This strategy cashes in on the ability that the influencer has garnered through their labour on the social media platforms to gain sustained engagement and intrigue because digital spaces are abhorrent fragmented which runs in contrary to the traditional advertising which often functions in the arena of shared public spaces in the form of banners, hoardings and televised adverts. Through embedding and integrating brand narrative into user-generated content, brands and organizations not just garner visibility but also establish and cultivate relational trust which enhances consumer loyalty and purchase intent. Hence, under the purview of attention economy, influencer culture plays the pivotal role of operating as a marketing mechanism as well as an attention management tool which aligns the objectives of the brand/organization with the conventional needs of digital visibility and participatory consumption (Dandona et al., 2025).

Patriarchal Dynamics: Digital culture has introduced a complex paradox towards the structures of patriarchy whereby it has often been perceived as a development that reinforces and challenges the hierarchies as well as the dictates of gender norms and sexuality. While some scholars advocate that digital platforms instrument the reproduction of patriarchal norms and further the susceptibilities of succumbing to the male gaze through algorithmic practices, commodity of femininity and surveillance practices which are witnessed prominently in femtech applications which tend to frame women as mothers and data subjects instead of recognizing them as autonomous individuals (Chen, 2025). The culture that is disseminated through the digital infrastructure and popularized often continues to imbibe a gendered discourse that is

perverse and privileges masculine authority through sustaining and perpetuating unequal power relations under the garb of entertainment (Javed et al., 2025). Whereas, the rise on online subcultures and activism whereby users are able to instigate a deliberation and contemplation through hashtag movements and web campaigns which intend to disrupt the gendered dynamics by forging spaces for marginalized voices that aim to contest against the systemic inequalities and articulate the need to emphasize on alternative gendered narratives (Wang, 2024; Grant, 2025). Digital interventions often accommodate counter-publics which aim to challenge and question the premises on which patriarchal power rests, it enables new kinds of solidarities and mass reach through challenging the status quo pertaining to gender. Digital culture plays the role of a double-edged sword which can very well be perceived as an arena of reproducing patriarchal norms and a catalyst for furthering the goals of feminist social justice through resistance and mobilization.

Monetization: It refers to the ability to garner monetary gains from the labour one performs on different social media platforms, the whims of monetization are explicitly arbitrary and precarious as they are dictated by the torrents of platform governance and socio-cultural mores, whereby influencers barely have the privilege of solely relying on the remuneration that the platform provides because of the inherent perils of algorithmic volatility and opacity of the payment structures which contribute to financial uncertainties (Christin & Lu, 2023; Annabell, 2025). Hence, the people who solely rely on their labour on social media platforms (i.e., their presence and content creation) tend to rely on different strategies for capitalizing on their visibility and credibility, these strategies range across brand collaborations, sponsored content, subscription models, establishing patron-client relations with their viewers who are willing to

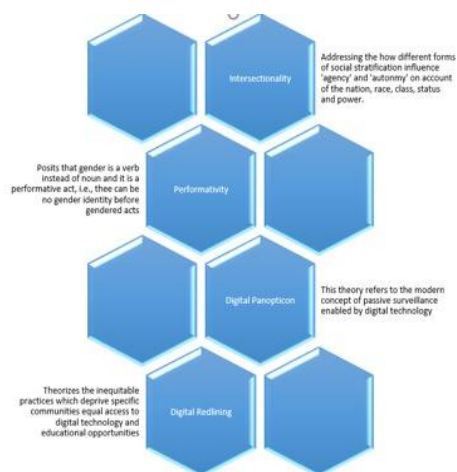
financially contribute etc (Adewunmi, 2024; Kumbo et al., 2024). Such practices pertaining to monetization are deeply entangled with the perpetuation of conventional gendered norms because influencers have to frequently navigate and maneuver through patriarchal norms through either confirming to the conventions of idealized femininity that is dictated by the adherence to prescribed gender roles for broader appeal and reach or through subverting the norms to cultivate a niche audience which resonate and align with feminist or counter-cultural values (Grant, 2025; Annabell, 2025), hence, monetization is not just an economic or transactional act but instead a cultural negotiation where influencers have to strike a balance between authenticity, the expectations of their audiences and structural inequalities to sustain their practice of digital labour.

Feminist Social Justice: While monetization under the purview of digital culture is often misunderstood and posed as commercial pursuit instead of acknowledging the complex negotiation of agency and autonomy within digital economies. Influencers who align with feminist discourse are often subject to epistemic challenges on account of the linguistic and comprehensive abilities of their audiences whereby they are often infantilized and their labour is trivialized because their intellectual acumen is often dismissed and perceived as mere self-promotion, which reflects the reinforcement of intellectual sexism and epistemic injustice across digital platforms (Medina, 2021; Guin & Gupta, 2025). Such injustices manifest through testimonial and hermeneutic marginalization wherein feminist voices are often discredited or deprived of interpretative resources that help articulate their experiences across monetized spaces (Fricker, 2007; Guin & Gupta, 2025). Due to the ambiguities pertaining to the premise upon which platforms practice with regards to policies regarding monetization, influencers often resort

to practices which often run the risk of compromising authenticity and undermine the epistemic agency of the influencers (Scharff, 2023; Pitafi & Awan, 2024). Such structural designs often overlook the structural precarity practiced by platform economies and the necessity for creators to assert autonomy through diversified income streams, feminist influencers operate within a paradox on the lines striving for financial sustainability and resisting the practices that epistemically silence them. Hence, the torchbearers of feminist social justice discourse often have to walk the tightrope of balancing the task of claiming legitimacy in the digital culture which runs contrary and conflates with economic survival with ideological compromise.

Theoretical Framework

This section attempts to mention the academic theories that this study deploys in the process of its investigation and the explication of its findings, this study attempts to draw theories prevalent in the conventional feminist discourse as well as those that are prominent in the study of information age/ fourth industrial revolution. These theories inform the insights that this study attempts to voice.



Theories deployed in the investigation and explication of the findings of this study

Intersectionality

Since Crenshaw's (1989) foundational articulation of intersectionality as a critique of single-axis frameworks in law and feminist theory, the concept has often been used to investigate and describe the inequalities within the digital contexts. Intersectionality remains a critical analytic for understanding how overlapping systems of oppression pertaining to race, gender, class, sexuality, and ability are reproduced and contested online, as well as, how its migration into digital spaces has generated both theoretical innovation and critique. It has been characterized as a "travelling theory" within digital feminist cultures on account of its popularity in online activism and blogospheres but warning of its tendency to become abstracted into individualistic practices of identity performance (Kanai, 2021). Across digital spaces, intersectionality often functions as a classificatory grid for ranking privilege rather than as a structural critique, recentering whiteness and liberal multicultural ideals rather than dismantling systemic inequalities. The application of intersectionality in online feminist cultures materializes as a heuristic for "knowing one's place" within economies of visibility and affect, raising concerns about commodification of difference in attention-driven platforms. Scholars highlight the role of algorithmic and infrastructural dimensions of digital capitalism argues that while intersectional feminism powers connective action in digital activism, the same infrastructures with regards to the inequalities concerning speed, visibility, algorithmic amplification run the risk of fragmenting solidarities and commodifying care, turning pain into a "public utility" within the attention economy (Alizada,2025). This resonates with critiques of neoliberal co-optation wherein intersectionality is mobilized as a branding strategy for inclusivity while masking structural exclusions, particularly of marginalized voices from the Global South and working-class women.

In digital humanities and technology studies, intersectionality is deployed and operationalized to interrogate digital divides and epistemic inequities, arguing that without intersectional analysis, technological design perpetuates systemic bias which are explicitly evident in facial recognition errors disproportionately affecting Black women. Intersectionality is not just descriptive but rather prescriptive because it avails methodological guidelines for inclusive research and design. Interdisciplinary deliberations that highlight the tensions between the radical origins of intersectionality and its institutionalization tend to suggest caution against only superficial models of diversity within digital scholarship and advocate for intersectionality as a constitutive analytic that interrogates the interplay of ‘capitalism, colonialism and digitality’ together (Alper .et al, 2022). The aforementioned caution aligns with the critiques surrounding how intersectionality runs the risk of depoliticization when reduced to mere representational metrics and that it should rather be deployed with keeping the objectives of structural transformation in stride. Intersectionality and the considerations that it espouses are indispensable and even often contested because while it is viewed as an integral tool in exposing algorithmic and platform mediated inequalities, it runs the risk of concretizing the vulnerability that is germinated through neoliberal driven attention economies. The challenge it faces and poses is to reclaim its critical edge with the intent of anchoring it in anti-racist, anti-discriminatory practices while accounting for the complexities of digital infrastructures and global feminist struggles.

Performativity

The theory of performativity holds that ‘gender should be perceived as a verb, instead of a noun’, i.e., gender is not what one is but rather what one does. It finds its origins in linguistic

philosophy and later expanded by feminist scholars and has played a pivotal role in instating an understanding of identity digital cultures. As digital platforms are often characterized by algorithmic visibility and networked interactivity which creates new arenas of performing, contesting and reconfiguring gender norms. Scholars often advocate that digital spaces provide the possibilities for subverting and reinforcing patriarchal structures. The theory of ‘doing gender’ conceives gender as an ongoing dialogue that is embedded in everyday interaction rather than a fixed attribute (West and Zimmerman, 1987). Under the purview of the digital context, the aforementioned theory translates in the observations pertaining to the social media metrics such as likes, comments, hashtags tend to constitute accountability structures that compel users towards reproducing normative femininity and masculinity. Influencer culture often rewards hyper-feminine aesthetics or hegemonic masculinity through reinforcing patriarchal standards on account of the amplification they garner through the algorithms. The performance of ‘gender’ is not merely expressive but rather tied to platform economies that monetize normative performances.

The theory of ‘undoing gender’ presents the framework of performativity in ways that emphasize the potential it holds for questioning the normative categories, it argues that gender norms can be subverted through iterative acts which fail or refuse to confirm (Butler, 2004). Digital spaces often provide an intriguing platform for such aforementioned undoing, which can be found in instances pertaining to non-binary influencers, queer content creators and trans activists that leverage visibility to challenge heteronormative scripts through the theory that cautions that undoing gender is constrained by the politics of recognition which are furthered by platform moderation, algorithmic bias and community standards that often reassert normative boundaries which render some lives “unlivable” within the digital economies due to the implicit

ostracization they are subjected to. Practices like online harassment and shadow bans further exemplify how patriarchal power adapts to digital infrastructures. The theory pertaining to “redoing gender” posits that gender cannot be undone but the structures of accountability can be transformed (Risman, 2009), they are exemplified in digital activism and web campaigns for instating gender-neutral pronouns which exemplify the redoing of gender as a collective renegotiation of norms. Such movements make use of the ability of connective affordances that social media enables to institutionalize new practices from inclusive language to corporate diversity pledges. Although, scholars often emphasize that such redoing often collates with commodification concerning feminist aesthetics which play out to be marketing tools and intersectional agendas risk dilution in influencer economies, which is why the task of redoing gender online oscillates between structural changes and co-option of patriarchal norms within the purview of neoliberal ethos. Across the aforementioned frameworks of performativity, the understanding that they espouse regarding how gender is performed digitally tends to maintain an air of ambivalence because while platforms enable radical visibility and experimentation with one’s identity but the algorithmic logics and attention economies tend to frequently reinscribe patriarchal hierarchies. Scholars advocate that digital cultures are inherently performative and keep conditioning subjectivities through techno-social assemblages (Lecker et. al, 2017), it poses a challenge for the project of feminist social justice to harness the subversive potential of digital performativity while resisting its capture by capitalist and patriarchal imperatives.

Digital Panopticon

Foucault conceptualizes the concept of *panopticon* in his book titled ‘Discipline and Punish’ as an integral part of modern society through which members are governed, this concept

was earlier put forth by Jeremy Bentham in disciplinary architecture for enabling constant surveillance and self-regulation, it has been extensively reconfigured in the digital age. The digital panopticon refers to the pervasive and algorithmically mediated surveillance which is embedded in social media platforms through data mining infrastructures and AI driven systems. Unlike Bentham's physical panopticon which was an architectural design for a corrective/reformative facility, its digital variant operates through invisible, decentralized mechanisms like data tracking, algorithmic profiling and predictive analytics which compel individuals to internalize norms and regulate their behaviour under the presumption of being perpetually observed (Manokha, 2018; Sekulovski, 2021). Scholars argue that digital surveillance not just monitors but instead reproduces gendered hierarchies which highlight how AI-driven systems pertaining to facial recognition to content moderation tend to encode binary gender assumptions which in turn erase nonbinary and transgender identities while reinforcing heteronormative norms. The feminist discourse poses that surveillance as a pressing issue regarding their autonomy and agency through highlighting how postfeminist cultures interest with neoliberal optics to produce a 'regulatory gaze' that disproportionately targets women through beauty filters, influencer economics and algorithmic metrics (Gill, 2019). Such a pervasive gaze amplifies patriarchal expectations of femininity and compels women to curate hyper-visible, compliant selves which are perceived as a digital extension of the male gaze (Nagel, 2025).

Digital Surveillance also posits a form of self-surveillance wherein individuals voluntarily conform to platform norms to perpetuate the social capital, this is linked with the commodification of empowerment, whereby women's online presence becomes an avenue of labour which are shaped by algorithmic incentives that reward normative gender performances

(Sharma & Kumar, 2024), this leads to the arguments concerning how patriarchal power adapt to digital infrastructures and embed control within economies of attention and data extraction. While the same infrastructure that enables surveillance also provides the requisite tools for feminist resistance, exposes gender based violence and demands accountability (D'Ignazio & Klein, 2020). Recent studies suggest that feminist activism is often captured by surveillance capitalism and risks fragmentation, as well as neoliberal co-option. The quest for feminist digital justice presents a framework which advocates for intersectional data governance, algorithmic transparency and design justice to counter patriarchal bias as well as reclaim authority (DAWN, 2023; Dubrofsky & Magnet, 2015).

Digital Redlining

The concept of digital redlining is adapted from the historical practices of spatial segregation and denial of resources, referring to the systematic exclusion or marginalization of groups through algorithmic design, data infrastructures and platform governance. Its inception can be traced back to how it was theorized in relation to racialized access to broadband and digital services (Gilliard, 2016), though its purview has further extended to include the investigation of gendered inequalities of digital economy. Digital redlining is furthered and implemented through opaque technological systems like search engine ranking, ad targeting and algorithmic moderation that reiterates hierarchies instated by patriarchy while presenting themselves as objective and neutral. It is argued that digital redlining confirms patriarchal norms by embedding gender bias into the architecture of platforms, for instance algorithmic oppression demonstrates how search engines sexualize women and erase feminist knowledge and reinforce misogynistic stereotypes (Noble, 2018). Studies also suggest that automated decision-making

systems disproportionately disadvantage women in the context of welfare and employment which furthered the structural inequalities under the guise of efficiency. Such practices consist of digital enclosure wherein women (especially those at the intersections of race, class and sexuality) are denied equitable access to visibility, resources and opportunities.

Digital redlining also plays an important role in influencer economics and digital labour platforms wherein algorithmic visibility regards femininity and penalizes deviation, which has led to feminist scholars arguing that social media and digital labour platforms instate a regime of self-policing wherein women are compelled to conform to hyper-feminized aesthetics and maintain algorithmic favor (Banet-Weiser, 2018). Such practices echo across neoliberal postfeminist discourse which frame empowerment as an individual branding rather than structural transformation, although, irrespective of the exclusionary practices, feminist social justice agenda have mobilized and voiced against digital redlining through data feminism and design justice frameworks. Scholars advocate that intersectional approaches to data ethics challenge the myth of algorithmic neutrality and demand participation in the design process as well (D'Ignazio and Klein, 2020). Certain initiatives like Algorithmic Justice League and fellow campaigns which advocate the need for inclusive AI showcase instances of efforts to overcome gendered bias in technological systems. Fellow exemplars of feminist digital activism attempt to leverage networked visibility to contest algorithmic erasure and create counter-publics and communities that resist patriarchal control. Although, the theory of digital redlining (also known as weblining) reveals an intriguing ambivalence because while platform economy is utilized to propel intervention and expose (as well as, challenge) algorithmic discrimination, it also highlights the underlying capitalist logics of platform economies which often co-opt efforts that are meant to subvert and thereby commodify diversity and inclusion. The propulsion and

promulgation of feminist social justice face the challenges of maneuvering between the tension between resisting the structures of patriarchy and transforming the very political economy of data.

Methodology

Critical feminist theory and digital sociology have informed the methods deployed in this research, it undertakes the objective of interrogating the influence of digital capitalism and influencer culture in amplifying or altering the patriarchal dynamics in the process of monetizing feminist expression and activism under the purview of the neoliberalism. The aforementioned objective was undertaken through applying ‘netnography’ and integrating discourse analysis and content analysis as research methods for investigating the linguistic and visual dimensions of digital feminist expression (and activism). The netnography of this study engaged with primary data sources derived from (i) social media platforms (like Instagram, Twitter and Youtube) which comprise of influencer driven feminist content, hashtag campaigns identified through searching posts consisting of hashtags like #MeToo, #Feminism and #Girlboss etc., as well as, sponsored posts and brand collaborations which explicitly frame feminist narratives. This study deployed the strategy of purposive sampling to identify influencers and campaigns which are spearheading the feminist discourse and engaging in various practices of monetization (even the comments and engagement with the selected content was utilized as the subject-matter of this study).

The analysis of this study was undertaken through the aforementioned analytical approaches, discourse analysis finds its roots in the Foucault’s theorization of power and

knowledge, as well as Butler's performative theory and this approach was used to analyze how feminist language and narratives are constructed, circulated and commodified under the ambit of influencer culture through addressing the question concerning how influencers are able to further feminist ideals under the purview of neoliberal frameworks and what discursive strategies normalize or challenge the patriarchal norms in monetized content, while content analysis was undertaken for systematically coding the visual and textual elements which were identified to be recurring themes, symbols and aesthetic patterns. This study considered the categories pertaining to the representation of empowerment (for instance, body positivity, choice feminism), commercial markers (like brand tags, affiliate links) along with engagement metrics (such as, likes, shares and comments) as plausible parameters of algorithmic amplification. This study strictly adhered to the prescribed ethical guidelines of netnography and fellow digital research and only assessed content that was publicly available, it practices anonymity regarding the identity of the influencers.

Demarcating the Dissent in the Discourse

Reinforcement of Patriarchal Dynamics

Monetization of the feminist rhetoric often takes myriad ways and forms, it has been seen as an implicit appropriation of patriarchal dynamics and subjugation to the male gaze under the garb of neoliberal self-branding environ, this vantage point raises an intriguing concern regarding how the feminist mission of imparting 'autonomy' and 'agency' has been hacked by the perverseness of the axiological conditions in society which are furthered by how these axiological standards are facilitated through the advent of digital capitalism and influencer

culture. Those who view this development advocate that platform economies exploit the desire for social change through repurposing and repackaging the feminist political critique as an individualized, marketable content (Schiller, 1999). The propulsion of the neoliberal logic has led to the co-option of ‘marketplace feminism’ which positions itself as an enabler of female empowerment through self-improvement, consumption and personal branding (Han, 2018). Platform economy has been accused of incentivizing content that attains high reach and warrants a predictable feedback whereby it consequentially prioritizes aesthetically conformist and palatable forms of feminism which are supported by the algorithmic infrastructure. Scholars have articulated the aforementioned development as an outcome of the dual nature of consumer feedback wherein positive reinforcement exacerbates harmful stereotypes that might compel female creators to prioritize physical appearance and sexual appeal over authentic political expression (Seuren, 2024). Such dynamics accelerate, amplify and appropriate patriarchal norms and subjugation to the male gaze under the garb of attesting valour to the ‘entrepreneurial self’ (Couldry & Hepp, 2017) whereby the measure of success is imbibed in the ideas of self-discipline and hyper-visibility which runs the risk of divorcing activism from its structural goals and rendering the struggle for feminist social justice into a consumable commodity through the creation of mechanisms that direct criticality into consumer-driven activity wherein the status quo and normative identity troupes are established to aggravate the economic and gender hierarchies instead of challenging them (Perry, 2018).

Re-evaluating and Revolutionizing through Feminist Social Justice

Irrespective of the risks pertaining to co-option, the advent of the digital still pertains a potent capacity to instrument the altercation of entrenched gender dynamics through providing an infrastructure for feminist social justice to disseminate information, mobilize and garner

support, along with organizing movements and deliberations in cases of instances where the the 'autonomy', 'agency' and 'differences' are being hindered. Platform economies provide a fertile ground for the aforementioned undertaking because they serve the function of facilitating 'networked counterpublics' (Trott, 2020) through offering space for marginalized groups to reinvent and create counter-discourses that question the mainstream patriarchally sanctioned narratives (Fraser, 1992). Digital culture facilitates an environ that is uniquely suited to the work of contemporary feminism on account of the fluidity and performativity that online identities enable users to engage in a wide variety of performances which disrupt the traditional binary understanding of gender through instrumenting the realization for fluid gender expressions and innovative identities (Webb & Temple, 2010). The digital infrastructure provides the scope for survivor-centric movements which utilize the mass content reach to generate feedback through which they face accountability amongst institutions and instigate contemplation and deliberation amongst the public opinion of different ways and forms of gender-based violence (Clark, 2016). Also, the development of digital culture has provided room for non-Western and intersectional voices with the ability to achieve autonomy and monetization which garners financial independence that implicitly becomes an implicit requisite for sustainable activism, as well as, further the goals of developing feminist policy and advocacy of design justice approaches that center marginalized experiences in addressing structural issues like gender-based violence (Constanza-Chock, 2020; Ruiz García, 2022). Hence, the advent of digital capitalism and influencer culture cultivate an inclusive, dynamic and globally networked feminist practice.

Conclusion

This study attempts to undertake a nuanced evaluation of the content and discourse pertaining to gender justice under the purview of digital capitalism and attention economy with the objective of assessing the extent to which these developments reinforce or reform patriarchal dynamics through combining the methodology of discourse and content analysis which systematically quantify the prevailing themes and critically deconstruct the rhetorical strategies that lie at the heart of practising digital feminism. The findings of the study suggest that monetization poses a pivotal challenge because of the inclination it holds towards monetary exchange which tends to be bent towards perverse and patriarchal underpinning. The analysis also reflect on the structural logic of digital capitalism which systematically channels feminist content in the direction of sensationalism which becomes the foreground of commercial viability and this bias which is driven by algorithmic prioritization tends to favour content that is either hypersexualized, emotionally provocative or centered around individualized consumer-based solutions (which are the core arguments in the reinforcement side of the deliberation). The observation of the study revealed that there is a significant correlation between high-engagement rates and discourses which are driven towards aesthetics and competitive self-branding which align with, instead of challenging the neoliberal valourization of the female entrepreneurial subject which exacerbates the economic pressure of procuring reach through confirming to the platform incentives which result in commodified ‘marketplace feminism’ that risks the neutrality of systemic critique.

Although, the study also found and acknowledged that notions of agency and autonomy were becoming more and more freely available for all and provided marginalized voices an unprecedented platform for participating in the global dialogue which is spearheading the goal of

re-evaluation and revolutionization of gender understanding (which forms the premise of the reformation hypothesis). Although, this vantage point also critically views the development and posits that the challenge now lies not in the availability of these tools but instead in the ways and approaches that users often succumb to for garnering metrics needed for success because this in turn tends to compromise the complexity of the message pertaining to feminist social justice by prioritizing easily digestible or sensational narratives, while being subject to the debilitating effects of trolling and cyber bullying.

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